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Article

30 Apr 2026 Alon Aviram, Eli Moskowitz, journalist reporting from Indonesia (name withheld), The Gecko Project

Indonesia: Nickel mining and smelting on Obi Island reportedly causes long-term toxic pollution contaminating drinking water; incl. cos comments

 Allegations

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internal emails show that for more than a decade, the company's own testing recorded carcinogenic wastewater repeatedly spilling [...]. By 2022, the village's main spring would be contaminated with high levels of chromium-6.

Two Indonesian environmental lawyers [...] said the evidence presented strong grounds for criminal prosecution.

This investigation is based on a review of hundreds of internal Harita documents and emails [...].

[...] In July 2022, [...], a PT Halmahera Persada Lygend staffer sent a report to an environmental and compliance manager at Harita Nickel. "There is an issue of pollution around the Harita Nickel Obi site area due to the activities of the nickel ore mining, processing, and refining plant," [...].

But PT Halmahera Persada Lygend repudiated the findings. In its response to the Guardian, the company stated that tests at the spring conducted between 2013 and 2021 showed compliance with government water quality standards, [...].

Electric vehicle battery manufacturers GEM Co., Jiangsu Easpring Material Technology Co. and Huayou Cobalt did not respond to repeated requests for comment. CATL stated that it "does not have direct business relations with Harita Group," is committed to building a globally responsible mineral supply chain and "opposes and prohibits any forms of practices that endanger public health and the environment in the operations of CATL and [its] suppliers."

CNGR Advanced Material Co., said that it is "currently conducting a comprehensive internal investigation" and will issue a statement by May 2nd 2025.

"When I cough, there is pus and blood," [...]. Stomach cramps and diarrhoea are frequent. "We don't know if it's the water. But we drink it every day."

[...] child suffer from raw, reddened skin, persistent rashes, and incessant itching.

Children, [...], had died. "My nephew had diarrhoea for a week. He didn't survive."

[...] a toxicologist who reviewed some of Harita's testing data [...] wrote that it was hard to draw firm conclusions [...] but that it showed "considerable contamination".

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Mercedes-Benz stated that while it does not source nickel directly, it maps its nickel supply chains in detail and cited the disposal of toxic tailings from HPAL processing facilities as a relevant topic. Further, it stated that in response to allegations of water pollution on Obi Island in 2022 it appointed a supply-chain auditing company to inspect Halmahera Persada Lygend and received reports of “solid results”. It added that Harita Nickel will conduct an audit based on the Initiative for Responsible Mining Assurance in the upcoming weeks.

Toyota said that it values the principle of “respect for humanity” and expects its suppliers to uphold human rights and avoid any violations, in line with the company’s global policies.

Tesla, BMW, Volkswagen, General Motors, Ford, Honda, and Volvo, did not respond to The Gecko Project’s request for comment. Click [here](#) to read responses from all companies and individuals from whom we sought comment.

Timeline

Indonesia: Nickel mining and smelting on Obi Island reportedly causes long-term toxic pollution contaminating drinking water; incl. cos comments

 **30 Apr 2026** Article

Indonesia: Civil society organizations call on bank to cease financing for Harita nickel smelter on Obi Island

3 Oct 2025 Article

Indonesia: CSOs and residents demand action from Harita Nickel over water pollution, flooding, and intimidation; incl. co. response

 **20 Aug 2025** Article
